THE CHARISMA IS BACK

THE HERO KARIZMA RETURNS AS THE KARIZMA XMR. IT COMES WITH MANY FIRSTS AND PROMISES TO BE A STRONG CONTENDER IN THE SEGMENT

BY RAHUL GHOSH

Back in the day when the first-generation Karizma was launched, it was nothing short of a revolution. After being out of action for some time, Hero has now relaunched the Karizma in an all-new avatar, calling it the Hero Karizma XMR. So, can the XMR rekindle the fire?

The XMR sure looks like a sleek sports tourer. Taking centrestage is the front fairing which looks well-integrated with the H-shaped LED headlamp unit. The LED DRL, too, looks fantastic on this motorcycle. The 17-inch alloys also go well with the overall design of the bike. Hero has also loaded the XMR with a unique adjustable windscreen. The unit is mechanically operable and works with a certain degree of preciseness. The 11-litre fuel tank is also well designed and fuses black panels to the overall body colour (our bike was yellow and black). The twin seat offers ample space for the rider and the pillion. The seat height, at 810 mm, should be comfortable for most frames. At the back, the side panels merge well with the small but bright LED tail light unit. As far as the instrument panel goes, Hero offers an LCD unit on the XMR. The small unit offers a plethora of data that can be sifted through via the left-side switch gear.

Hero has taken a big step as far as the engine of the Karizma goes. It's a brand new 210 cc motor that gets a DOHC set-up and liquid cooling, both a first for a Hero product. The engine churns out 25.5 bhp and 20.4 Nm of torque. The Karizma also gets a slip-assist clutch and transfers power to the rear wheels using a 6-speed gearbox. The bike is based on a steel trellis frame.

The XMR starts up smooth and near instantly there is a feel of improvement as far as the engine is concerned. The clutch is light and the gearbox shifts precisely into gear. The acceleration is not blistering fast. but there is plenty of punch on offer. On the go, the XMR impresses with its tractable nature. Cruising in 6th gear, we could go as low as 40 kmph even in the city, for the XMR will demand fewer gear changes. There is plenty of torque available, too, and this results in a smooth take-off from lower speeds without having to shift down.

When it speeds up, the XMR touches the 90 kmph mark with ease. From then on, it takes a longer time to attain higher speeds. Considering we were riding on traffic-infested city roads, the fastest we went was 110 kmph and even at that speed, the motor felt reasonably relaxed. The XMR's suspension is well-tuned to absorb bumps and ruts. Even the rumble strips didn't bother me much and the longer rides, too, should be a comfortable affair. ■

Engine 210 cc, liquid-cooled, DOHC
Power 25.5 bhp/ 20.4 Nm@7,250 rpm
Kerb weight 163.5 kg
Price ₹1.73 lakh (ex-showroom, Delhi)

